overstatement: Israel does not have many natural resources, and as a small country it will never be a manufacturing powerhouse; its prosperity is closely linked to having an educated workforce. (The results, notably, did not include boys in ultra-Orthodox schools, which would undoubtedly have pushed Israel's score much lower.)

The next day, though, Bennett's education ministry announced a plan to invest 136 million shekels over four years to teach students about Judaism—in foreign countries. He said that the programs, to be offered across Europe, would "strengthen Jewish identity and connection to Israel on the part of students at Jewish schools around the world." The sum is a drop in the bucket, less than tenth of a per cent of the education ministry's annual budget. But it was a revealing sign of priorities. "Learning about Judaism and excellence in the subject is more important in my eyes than mathematics and the sciences," Bennett said at a conference in 2016.

Some *haredim* have rebelled against these strictures from within: there are business incubators that cater to the community, and job training programs aimed at closing the educational gaps. Moshe Friedman founded a company called KamaTech in Tel Aviv that matches ultra-Orthodox applicants with high-tech employers. Friedman, a self-taught programmer, predicted that the rabbis would one day "catch up" with younger people frustrated with a life of poverty and isolation. But it is a slow process—so others take more dramatic steps.

Dasi and Ya'akov

Esti Weinstein's suicide note was 183 pages long. It was a novel, really, the story of Dasi and Ya'akov, a young couple from one of the largest Hasidic sects. They married when Dasi was seventeen—an arranged union, of course, as was the custom in their community. They met only once before the wedding, two young people on the cusp of adulthood, and yet still children in so many ways. Ya'akov gave "the speech", as Dasi called it, the awkward mumblings about how difficult it was to follow the rules of their order, the restrictions on sex and intimacy. "I pitied the thin boy in front of me, sitting with drooped shoulders, his hands together in front of his body, and him swaying uncomfortably," Dasi recalled. "His overall appearance was far from being perfect but, touching in his humiliation, it caused me to feel relaxed next to him."